

PRELUDES AND FUGUES

An anthology

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Introduction

I once attended a talk by the poet Craig Raine on his libretto to the opera *The Electrification of the Soviet Union* (music by Nigel Osbourne, stage direction by Peter Sellars, libretto published by Faber and Faber in 1986). Raine had been approached by Osbourne to write a libretto based on Pasternak's novella *The Last Summer*, this being chosen by Osbourne because it was (in Osbourne's words) 'The most musical book he knew.' Raine was completely taken off-guard by this. He did not at the time, nor later when he was giving the talk on his completed libretto, know what Osbourne had meant. To me, the musicality of *The Last Summer* shines through and is one of the main delights of this work, yet an excellent poet such as Raine, who surely has some well-developed concept of music, did not see it at all.

This is not an isolated occurrence. T.S. Eliot wrote a well-known essay entitled *The Music of Poetry*¹, in which he never explains what he means by 'music' in poetry. The closest he gets to a definition seems to be the highly circular,

... a 'musical poem' is a poem which has a musical pattern of sound and a musical pattern of the secondary meanings of the words which compose it, and that these two patterns are indissoluble and one.

Thus we learn of Eliot's opinion (which I wholeheartedly agree with) that the 'music' of poetry is more than the rhymes,

¹ In: *On Poetry and Poets*, Faber and Faber 1957.

assonances or alliteration that may be there and certainly more than the rhythms of feet and metre which we hear. Meaning plays an essential role too. But nowhere in this essay does Eliot explain what he means by 'music,' except by appealing to the reader's preconceived idea of what is meant by music *qua* music.

We get a bit closer to what Osbourne was driving at a little later when Eliot writes that 'a play of Shakespeare is a very complex musical structure.' In other words, the musicality of a piece of literature of whatever length is an attribute that incorporates its entirety and overall structure. These are further hints that the music of poetry or literature is not about rhyme or alliteration or metre but something more, perhaps something that introduces, develops and concludes a theme in the way musical form does. Music that really is music must attempt to be more than a catching ditty or mere tuneful phrase. In this respect, Pasternak's novella *The Last Summer* is highly musical, at least in my opinion as well as Osbourne's.

In Eliot's very last paragraph, where perhaps a summing-up is expected, he introduces new ideas for his essay that hint at possible future developments of his thesis that align closely to what has been said about musicality involving the entirety of a piece.

I think that a poet may gain much from the study of music: how much technical knowledge of musical form is desirable I do not know, for I have not that technical knowledge myself.

and

The use of recurrent themes is as natural to poetry as to music. There are possibilities for verse which bear some analogy to the development of a theme by different groups of instruments; there are possibilities of transitions in a poem comparable to the different movements of a symphony or a quartet; there are possibilities of contrapuntal arrangement of subject-matter. [...] More than this I cannot say, but

must leave the matter here to those who have had a musical education.

I have also, for some time, thought that a closer connection between literature and music would be beneficial to both. This volume is a modest contribution in this direction.

The *Well Tempered Clavier* by J.S.Bach, usually referred to informally as ‘The 48,’ is a set of two books, each book containing a prelude and fugue in each of the 24 possible major and minor keys. It was written to showcase the tuning that had been recently introduced on keyboard instruments such as organs and harpsichords, in which every octave is divided into 12 equal intervals (semitones) and therefore as a result the keyboard can play equally well in every possible key. This is of course nowadays the usual tuning on a piano but at the time was a major innovation.

Bach’s 48 successfully does all of this and the idea has frequently been copied, for example by Chopin in his *Preludes*. But it achieves much more than this. It is a showcase for composition: each key inviting the composer to write in a different style, always within the constraints of an introductory prelude followed by a contrapuntal fugue – this word literally meaning ‘flight’ and was by Bach’s day a well understood and developed musical form. Furthermore, composers, performers and those listening to music have learnt to associate particular moods or emotions with each key. For example, the key of E♭ major is associated with the ‘heroic,’ as used for example in Beethoven’s *Eroica* symphony or Strauss’s tone poem *Ein Heldenleben*.²

Whether these moods associated with keys is an innate part of our psychological make-up or a synthetic product of the way composers write music is a moot point, but there is no doubt that pieces of music in different keys sound very different in terms of mood and emotion, and this can easily be verified by playing the same music transposed from one key to another and listening to

²See the appendix for a more detailed list. It is of course somewhat naïve to associate a simple list of moods to musical keys: the mood very much depends on the composer’s treatment of the music too, such as whether it is fast or slow or a dance or a song, etc.

the differences.

The same applies to literature. If anything can convey emotion, literature surely can, and there are considerably more traits available to the author or poet than the 24 keys available to Bach. A literary 'key' could reasonably mean a mood, described perhaps by a set of three or four adjectives, and 'writing in that key' would then mean writing about something that represents or encapsulates that mood. To keep things simple, one's writing could focus on a single subject, though in music as well as literature 'modulations' of the key or mood are frequent and, for example, the much-used musical form called *sonata form* is based on contrasting two themes initially presented in different keys, to be developed and then finally as a kind of resolution, presented at the end in the same key.

With all this in mind, this volume is a small set of preludes and fugues in literature. Each author has been asked to focus on particular moods, emotions or traits and to write about a person, object or place that conveys them. Modulations (contrasting emotions) were not discouraged and indeed Bach's 48 contain many modulations too, but the focus is on one primary subject. For that subject the authors were asked to write an introductory 'prelude' setting out the main subject in its key, followed by a 'fugue' or story or poem involving it, which might be in a different literary style.

Of course, to what extent these pieces are musical is up to the reader to judge, but we have all found the exercise useful in finding new ways to think about what we write and in expanding and developing literary style and technique in writing. We sincerely hope you will enjoy reading them too.

Pipe, glass, bottle

Sadie Kaye

Form strives to liberate itself from matter. . .
Étienne Gilson, *Painting and reality*,
Princeton University Press, 1957.

Pipe, verre, bouteille de vieux Marc.
Pablo Picasso, 1914.

Prelude.

O pluck out the Spanish songs
on this sketchiest of false guitars,
and sing out its transformation!

Sing out the thunderous vocation
of a torn and ragged sheet,
a single page of frozen newsprint,

and pipe your dreams through the work
with the scantest splash of véritable vieux Marc!
Santé! Bottoms up!

Fugue.

Matter seeks shape to appropriate
and mould itself to living taste:
so the artist acts—

and art is matter's form:
this material and form are proximate
yet form will strive to liberate

itself from such worldly stuff;
though, without matter's grist,
it cannot truly subsist.

In this way art's substance may subsume
anything it could desire,
because art can,

and should the artist expropriate
primary matter from a futurist rag
pasted down on board

this cheap newsprint will then become
the boldest of icons, preserved forever
to grace a different world.

Being someone

Sadie Kaye

[title TBC]

Prelude.

Rollercoaster

as soon as i was aware i was someone
i found i was riding
this big dipper
being told
who i am

i try to please
i try to look happy
i do what they say

there are
splashes
of bright light
on this ribbon of a ride

i
squeeze

into this life
it's the one they gave me
it's all i can imagine

so i'm spiralling along

the track
is a steel wave and i am
 circles locked
 in onto
 round it
 going

a dark shadow
running counter
to the wave of the track
shows

where i should be going

B U T

i can't choose anything
i choose the non-choice
i choose the only ride on offer
i wasn't shown how to go anywhere else

and it's going
 too fast
too fast
 to let me get off

Fugue.

Absence of agenda

today I don't have an agenda
I won't write a poem on its absence

today I'll live life as a Me
or is that an agenda? maybe

there are people out there
who don't know my Me at all
they've never seen my Me never said Hello
they think that they know
who this Me is I am
they say the Me that I am is not Me it's You Are
I say they can't know
and I am the Me that they might see
were they to open their I's
not the You Are they imagine

but they never see my Me only You Are
because of absence of Hello

I'm living today as my Me
with almost no agenda at all
I'll tell others not to impose
their You Are on my Me

of course I have an agenda
Me is my agenda today

Jennifer

Sadie Kaye

Prelude.

Jennifer hated being called Jenny. That was what they had called her when she'd been a little girl. It was always 'Jenny, you've got to do it this way,' and 'Jenny, you know it's not safe to do that.' She'd seen the other girls and boys doing all sorts of things. They always seemed to have more fun than her, going out, playing together in the park or on the waste-ground that lay behind it. But she was never allowed to go out and play with them. 'It wasn't safe,' they said.

She'd been a diligent but average schoolchild, doing the work that had been asked of her and rarely missing any assignment. Nevertheless, nothing she had learnt about really sparked anything inside her. She just got on with her work because they told her she must. And they had explained that if she did badly at her schoolwork and failed her exams it would make her life much more difficult later on. She believed them. Maths and English, they said, were particularly important. She worked hard at both. Spelling some words in English was difficult. So many words seemed to have many possible spellings and endings like -ant and -ent always sounded so similar that she never knew which

was right and which was wrong. But when she did get it wrong she got a nasty red scrawl over her essay and she didn't like that at all. Maths too. It wasn't always easy to remember all those things they told her to do when they gave her maths work. And to be perfectly honest, she didn't always see why she had to do the calculations in the way they said. Some of the better maths-whizzes in the class said she was being silly and it was obvious what to do, but she didn't get it. Still, she hated the red crosses on her work and the 'Jenny, you can do better than this,' comments. So, with a mixture of rote learning and hard work, she did well enough to pass the exams and get the sort of results that her parents were at least not very disappointed with.

It was important that her parents weren't cross with her for not being particularly good at maths or spelling, or any other subject. Fortunately, they never said much that was particularly critical. But they did go on rather about how clever her cousins were. They all had rather good results at A-level and were going to university.

Jennifer muddled through her A-levels. The subject she liked more than others was history. It always seemed to be a lot less effort to read a history textbook, absorb the facts she'd just read and write her history essay. Not everyone in her class said that remembering the details—especially dates—was straightforward, but it was not so difficult, she found. Her father, however, only had interests in science and technology, and dismissed any talk of history. Her mother, who had married him early without studying anything in particular, supported him. There was no point in studying the past, they said. What really matters is the here and now. And the future. How is the future and all the technology going to evolve? And in what way will you be part of it? There was so much happening in the world with the introduction of electronics and computers and silicon chips everywhere that it was important for a girl of Jenny's age to learn about these new innovations and not waste time with history and the past.

Jenny! No, she was Jennifer.

But in the end, she believed them. The future was where it was at. If only she'd known, she thought many years later, how

difficult the future would be, and how important it was to strike out on one's own, but at the time her parents' advice seemed perfectly sensible.

She left school at eighteen and found ordinary work in a supermarket and later on waitressing at a local pizzeria. At some point only a couple of years later, she met Joe in a pub where she was with some people she knew. They chatted a bit. Or at least, he chatted to her and she listened hard and nodded. He had just returned from doing a degree at university and was starting up with a career in an insurance company. He seemed to like her and his career was progressing very well. In due course he proposed and they moved in together into their very own flat. To Jennifer, this was growing up at last. Adulting, as they call it. Her experience had been thankfully rather straightforward, and she looked forward to her future life as a housewife and hopefully as a mother.

Fugue.

Jennifer was spending a rather normal day at home, doing the housework and planning the meals she'd be making in the next few days. It was at times like these, in the morning, when she was on her own in the house with nothing much to do – nothing except to make sure everything was organised, clean and tidy – that she thought about where she had come from and how she had got here. Joe's work had gone well and after only three years he had been earning enough for them to be able to buy their first house together. But the ghost of little Jenny followed her everywhere. Jenny who was always worried she'd do the wrong thing. Jenny who would be criticised for not managing her life properly. No, she told the ghost, emphatically. She'd really made it. There was nothing wrong. She had a secure life that was comfortable enough. But. But what? But nothing.

Joe, she knew, was sitting behind his desk at that very moment, with a computer in front of him and a telephone to the side. He'd be sending off emails and making phone calls and doing all his insurance work. She wasn't really sure what it exactly was that he did. He occasionally mentioned statistics and probability and used the complicated word 'actuary' rather often, whatever that meant, but exactly what his work was and how it earned money was beyond her. But it did earn money and she was grateful for that.

Generally speaking, she kept the house clean and tidy. It was her work and she understood that she had to do her share of work too. And it was important that her work was good enough. Good enough for Joe when he came home and good enough for her parents and for Joe's parents when they came to visit. The ghost of Jenny said that she must avoid those carping teachers' reports – even those from teachers from her own family after she'd grown up and become someone's wife. She must avoid all those ugly red Biro crosses on her work, avoid all the comments saying, 'Jenny, you can do better than this.'

She did well. She did her work diligently with care. No one complained. No one gave her bad marks for housework. But

there was one subject for which she only seemed to get bad marks, and she was afraid she would never pass the exams in. Oh, little Jenny was such a disappointment. It was true that this subject was hardly ever mentioned in conversation and certainly not raised directly to her – not by Joe’s parents nor by hers. Yet she could see in their faces all their disappointment and could hear their criticism in the way they skated round the subject, always avoiding it, always talking about other people or something else entirely.

Joe and she had been married five years now, but they had not yet had their first child.

As far as she could tell, this was perfectly fine for Joe. He had not been complaining, but she felt the future grandparents’ disappointment intensely. She didn’t know why there was no child yet and she didn’t know what to do. Her periods always arrived normally and she had stopped taking contraceptives when she and Joe had moved into the house together just over two years ago. But nothing had happened yet. It was not a subject she felt comfortable talking to Joe about. He seemed happy enough with the status quo. And wasn’t her task in life to support him in what he wanted?

This was a frequent refrain going through her thoughts as she started with her daily housework. Perhaps that was because she always started with the bedroom where these thoughts were focused like a knot in her crotch and she only tidied and cleaned the other rooms later. And always, at this time in the morning, she wondered if she *really* wanted children. She thought she did. When they had married she had been very sure of it. And, of course, as well as this, she wanted what Joe wanted. At the same time, she wanted what her parents wanted and – to only a slightly lesser extent – what Joe’s parents wanted. Yet no one ever talked about it. Still, she knew both parents’ hopes and wishes for her. She didn’t have any brothers or sisters and Joe’s only sibling was a sister in a relationship with another woman who didn’t keep in touch with Joe or her parents-in-law except at Christmas and were showing no sign of any interest in children. Somehow, it seemed to be up to her and Joe.

It was still quite early in the morning. Her day always started with her making breakfast for Joe in her nightie with a bathrobe over. His breakfast was important to him, she knew. That was why it was her first task every day. When he had left for work she could look after herself a bit: this was the time for her to clean herself up and get dressed.

Today she was wearing one of her favourite dresses. It was nothing special, but it was perfect for the daytime and felt comfortable. She'd had it for only a few months but proportionately had worn it rather a lot since then. It was made of a thin and slightly stretchy dark green knitted fabric with a simple pattern showing white fern leaves. It fitted her well and, when she had bought it, Joe had said it showed off her figure nicely. She smiled to herself as she remembered him saying this – the memory gave her a lot of pleasure. He didn't compliment her very often and as a result it was the more valuable when he did. She did have a good figure – this was one of the things she could be proud of and another thing to keep an eye on and maintain. One more of her duties as a housewife. Her breasts weren't particularly large, but she made up for this with a flat tummy, fairly narrow waist and hips that were not so very broad. The dress was slim enough to show off her waist and stretchy enough to show off her modest breasts and hips. It still had on it a tag saying, 'Do not remove this tag.' She didn't know what the tag was for, so she hadn't dared remove it.

She started in the bedroom, as was her habit. She looked round, scanned the room, putting away one or two items in drawers. This particular morning she noticed the bed's LEDs flashing.

As she watched the flashing lights, she recalled the excitement of moving into her first real house. Joe had insisted they do everything properly. They had enough money, he said, so they might as well. 'Properly,' according to Joe, was to get the most modern of mod cons throughout. Internet of Things, he called it. Everything was connected to the internet. Even the bed. And AI was everywhere. Jennifer got out her phone and logged on to the bed's web page to see what it was that the bed wanted.

It turned out it was time to change the sheets. Somehow it felt to

her like it was only the day before yesterday when she'd done that last, but Jennifer realised she had to obey. She started stripping the bed, putting aside the throw to go over the bed that did not need washing and also the duvet and pillows, but making a pile of the sheet, duvet cover and pillow cases. The bed's firmware kept a record of how often she did this. It could also inform her of the days when the mattress needed turning over or replacing completely. Fortunately, the current mattress, which had been new the day they moved in, would probably last another year.

She picked up the pile of dirty linen and took it to make a pile outside the washing machine and then returned to the bedroom. She'd deal with the washing later. Returning to the bedroom with clean linen from the cupboard on the landing, she made the bed carefully, making sure there were no creases in the sheets or lumps in the duvet. If there were any, it would be sure to let her know.

With the bed made, she went round the bedroom with duster and furniture polish. All the surfaces. Chest of drawers, wardrobe, dressing table. It was her usual routine, but she tried to avoid looking into the dressing table mirror. She really did not want to see what she looked like today.

Too late. It had seen her.

'You look tired,' said the dressing table. She kept silent but she felt its truth.

With an effort, she finished her dusting in the bedroom. Just as she'd finished and was leaving the bedroom to return the duster to the kitchen where it was kept, she passed the dressing table again.

'Jennifer?'

She turned and looked at it.

'Take ten minutes out for a cup of tea. Then come back and do the vacuuming.'

She nodded. She really needed a mid morning break.

With a comforting warm mug of tea in her hand she entered the living room and sat down. The sofa was on a side wall with the

large window and glass door to the small verandah on her left and the doorway on her right. In front of her was a huge television. As she sat down with her tea, sensors in the sofa triggered the television on, and it started blurting out one of the many news channels.

‘Volume down,’ said Jennifer. She wasn’t ready to hear whatever news there was today just yet and there was no way of turning the television off completely.

It was a lovely sunny day and the sky was a beautiful blue with a few cotton-wool clouds floating across. Jennifer realised she would much rather be sitting against the right hand wall of the sitting room, looking out of the big window at the sunshine outside. It would be easy enough to move the sofa to face a different direction. But as soon as she had had this thought she knew how impossible it was. The sofa had to face the television – that was obvious, that was what Joe wanted. If she dared to move the sofa he might be tempted to move the television to some position in front of the window and that would block her view completely. She dismissed her alternative reality of enjoying sunshine from the window for what it was – pure fantasy.

Suddenly the television channel switched over and the volume blurted back on loud.

‘Switching to fantasy,’ said the television. It was a film: one of the *Lord of the Rings* films. ‘You’ll like this one. It’s the one where the dragon wakes up and starts roaring fire.’

‘Turn it off.’

‘You know I can’t do that,’ it said.

‘Volume to minimum then.’

With the television’s sound still uncomfortably loud, Jennifer tried to ignore the television and focused on her mug of tea. If it wasn’t for the hobbit trying to steal something from the dragon and the interminable background music she thought she might possibly be able to relax like this.

Ten minutes later – no more, for the kettle in the kitchen where

she had made her tea had been timing her break – she got up from the sofa, got out the vacuum cleaner and took it into the bedroom. She vacuumed all round the bed and was just considering moving on to give the carpet on the landing her attention when her phone went off. It was some message. She turned off the vacuum cleaner and briefly enjoyed the sudden peaceful quiet this action brought. Then, remembering her phone had gone off, she wandered off to check.

It was a text from the hoover. The message said she'd missed a bit under the bed. There was an attachment with a photograph showing where she'd slipped up. Like a parking fine for housewives, she thought with a sarcastic smile on her face. Joe had recently received a parking fine. The letter had arrived in the post with a photograph of his car in the offending place where he had parked it. He had been furious.

Sighing a sigh, she returned, turned the vacuum cleaner back on, went to the dirty bit of carpet under the bed and made amends for her misdemeanour. With a sinking feeling, she suddenly realised that she had no idea if the hoover's email messages were all blind-copied to Joe at his work. And all the other gadgets. Was that why he liked Internet of Things?

She tried to bury the thought and continued on through the rest of the house doing her best not to miss all those little out of the way spots where dust and dirt accumulate.

About an hour later, she had finished. She'd been everywhere with the vacuum cleaner, she thought. She turned it off and counted to a hundred, listening out for any further messages on her phone.

Nothing. She sighed a sigh of relief and enjoyed the peace for two whole minutes.

Then she carried the vacuum cleaner back to the cupboard where it was kept. One of the house pixies showed her where to stow it away. She said good morning to him and enquired after his health.

'Good, thank you,' he replied. 'You did excellent work there.'

Don't forget that tomorrow you have to Hoover the sofa, cushions and chairs.'

She nodded and turned to the kitchen.

She unstacked the dishwasher from the night before then cleared the breakfast table from Joe's breakfast. Another house pixie told her how to rinse the items and stack the dishwasher with the dirty crocks and cutlery, reminding her what items went where and how to avoid items touching each other so they do not scratch or break when the dishwasher is turned on. She knew all this of course – she'd heard it hundreds of times – but listened carefully and did what she had been told. Better safe than sorry, she told herself.

The dishwasher wasn't ready to go on yet. 'I'm not ready to go on yet,' it said, out loud. So she moved on to filling the washing machine with the dirty sheets from the bed. Absentmindedly, she added detergent and twisted the knob in her usual fashion to select the programme, but the machine admonished her: 'For that load the low temperature cotton programme is better.'

Silly Jenny!

No, she was Jennifer, and she was going to get it right. She changed the programme and turned the machine on.

Breathing deep breaths to keep calm she looked at the clock. It was lunch time. She'd not had any breakfast and suddenly realised that she was hungry.

As she made herself a simple lunch of pasta with pesto and a side salad, she thought about what she might make for Joe this evening for his main meal. She fancied making a fish pie for a change. There were some nice potatoes that would mash well and only yesterday she'd looked in the freezer and saw some tasty looking frozen cod that had been there for a while and needed using up. It had positively been begging to be cooked and eaten. And what's more, she would enjoy it too, for a change. Joe ate too much meat, she thought, and it would do them both good to have some fish for a change. And for pudding, an apple crumble would be perfect. It would be a chance both to finish off some

apples that had been around a bit and for her to prove to Joe that she can cook, really. Not just ready meals, but her very own crumble topping and stewed apple. And the more she thought about it the more she realised she fancied cooking her own food tonight and making something she would like to eat as well, for a change. And she so much wanted Joe to know that she was capable of it.

‘But *you* know you *can*’t cook, not *really*,’ replied the cooker with emphasis, reading her thoughts.

‘Shut up cooker, what *you* know?’ said little Jenny, aged 14, entering from the hallway. She must have been playing Joe’s computer game in his study. ‘You never ate any of Jennifer’s meals.’

‘I didn’t have to. I heated them up and I inspected them. From what I saw, I really wouldn’t have wanted to taste them even if I could.’

Jennifer buried her head in her hands as she sat at the table, her lunch mostly eaten. She was grateful to Jenny for supporting her but she just wanted some peace right now. Jenny often turned up this time of day. Sometimes the two of them had a long chat about the old days, but today she just wanted some quiet. In any case she had to prove to everyone that she really could cook.

She got out the kitchen scales, flour, sugar and butter. She might as well make a start and make the crumble topping. And the fish—she should defrost that too. She went to the freezer to get the fish out.

‘What are you doing? You know Joe hates your fish pies.’ said the freezer. ‘It would be much better to make a shepherd’s pie with the potatoes. Plenty of nice lamb mince here. Let me show you.’

The LEDs in the lamb mince started flashing red and green. Somehow the frozen cod she’d seen yesterday was nowhere to be found.

‘Oh OK,’ said Jennifer. ‘Since you insist.’

‘And, while you’re here,’ said the freezer, ‘I really hope you are not planning to make an apple crumble for Joe. You know it will turn out badly and he will be unimpressed. There’s a delicious ready-made apple pie here to defrost and cook; it’s a new recipe and was a special at the supermarket. From the *Chef’s specials* range. Social media indicates a 98% satisfaction rate for this pie. And what’s more, house records show at least one tin of custard available. That way you won’t have to impose on him that homemade slop you call custard either.’

‘I suppose you are right,’ said Jennifer and pulled out the mince and pie from the freezer.

Returning to the kitchen, she put away all the things for the crumble she’d planned. Little Jenny came up to her and gave her a hug.

‘It’s not as bad as all that,’ she said. ‘You’ll save a bit of time not making the crumble. Why don’t you go for a walk in the park?’

Jennifer felt inadequate, but saw the sense in this. It was true, she realised. She had nearly two hours spare and a walk in the park was a lovely idea.

She checked out of the window. Bright sun, strong wind, not so warm.

‘There could be a shower or two later on,’ said little Jenny who was standing next to her.

Jennifer remembered how, one day coming home from school, she’d been caught in torrential rain. It had come from nowhere with no notice whatsoever. The cloud above burst open. In no time at all she had been soaked through. Soaked through her jacket to her shirt and down the inside of her skirt into her knickers. There was rain running down her legs into her shoes, soaking her socks. She walked home uncomfortably – squelch squelch squelch – as the sky brightened up. She was still soaked through when she arrived home under a crystal blue sky.

When she got in the house, she burst into tears and her mother told her to ‘Snap out of it.’ She went up to get into dry clothes but was never warm that evening. The next day she had a bad cold

which she blamed on the rain, but her mother said there were no germs in rain. It was just an old wife's tale.

And now she was an old wife. Maybe not so old, but. What to wear outside if rain was possible? With her head low, she walked into her bedroom to get changed. There was an elderly woman sitting on a chair in the corner of the room.

'Who are you?'

'I'm Jennifer,' said the woman.

She turned her back to ignore the intruder, got out of one of the drawers a pair of jeans and put them on. The chest of drawers said, 'Not a good idea. Cotton soaks up water and you will be cold and soaked through again.' She took them off and put on a pair of leggings. She felt cold.

Old Jennifer tut-tutted and asked what top she would wear. She hadn't decided. A non-cotton top layered-up with a fleece would be perfect, but she didn't have anything like this. In the end she screamed silently and put on an old T-shirt – the only one she had that wasn't cotton – and a jumper. She'd wear a raincoat over it all and people wouldn't see. And hopefully the rain – if it came – wouldn't be so strong to go through the coat and soak her through.

She inspected herself in the mirror and felt Little Jenny's eyes boring into her. 'What are you going to wear over those leggings?' she asked.

Jennifer had thought, 'Maybe nothing,' but saw her point. Those legs. Especially the thighs. A miniskirt was ideal but the only ones she had were denim – the evil cotton. A long woollen skirt? Scratches. Gets heavy when wet.

'You're over-thinking' said the wardrobe. 'If it doesn't rain you'll be boiled alive in all that.'

'And if it does rain hard you'll be soaked through just like before,' said Jenny.

'What will Joe think?' said the old lady, watching avidly from the corner of the room.

‘About the clothes I am wearing? That I am dowdy. It’s his word. Sometimes he says I dress dowdy and I don’t like it when he says that. But at least he can’t see me now.’

‘It works the other way too. What do you think he is doing right now?’

‘He’s at work,’ said Jennifer, and was suddenly unsure.

‘If he falls out of love with you he has every opportunity to –’

‘But he loves me. He said so last week.’

‘Or *when*, then. Not *if*.’

‘And what about your face?’ said the dressing table.

Jennifer looked at herself in the mirror. It had a point. There was a bad spot – from an in-growing hair perhaps – on her right cheek. She’d never be able to conceal that. And her eyebrows! When had she last plucked? Only last week, she thought, but it was a disaster. In desperation she grabbed the tweezers and started plucking. But her hurry made things worse rather than better.

‘You are just like me, aren’t you?’ said little Jenny, materialising from behind the dressing table mirror. ‘Silly Jenny, when you are not too timid you’re always in a hurry. And the result is just as bad.’

She was right.

‘What will Joe think?’ said the old lady.

There was no way Jennifer could go out today. She collapsed on the bed and cried.

‘Pull yourself out of that,’ said the old teddy from the top shelf of the wardrobe. It was Jennifer’s old teddy bear, she’d kept it as her only link to her childhood as Little Jenny. ‘Crying won’t help anyone. Smarten yourself up and get ready for when Joe gets home.’

‘At least someone has some sense round here,’ said the old woman.

Jennifer nodded. She got off the bed, straightened the sheets and

throw.

The teddy insisted on being taken down so he could see what was going on. Jennifer pulled him out and put him on the bedside table. She went back to the wardrobe and picked out one of her more revealing strappy dresses from the wardrobe. It was going to show a bit of cleavage, and she hoped she could get away with it.

‘Oh, you’re being brave now, wearing that,’ said the teddy. ‘But will you pull it off?’

‘More importantly,’ said Old Jennifer, ‘will Joe?’ She laughed, but Jennifer did not enjoy the joke.

There was a padded push-up bra that might help. She dug in the drawer for it. She took off her top and put the new bra on, and slipped the dress on over her head.

‘That’s better,’ said Little Jenny.

She nodded and checked herself in the mirror. It was almost OK – and would have to do. She flung off her trainers, leggings and socks and, still sobbing slightly, put on a pair of tights, picked out a pair of shoes and put them on.

‘Make-up time!’ said the dressing table.

Struggling with her emotions, Jennifer attended to her face. Concealer to hide the spot and eyebrow pencil to tidy up the mess from earlier. Foundation. Powder. Eyeshadow, eyeliner – this was always tricky – and mascara. It would have to do.

‘You mustn’t cry any more. The make-up will run if you do,’ said Old Jennifer.

Jennifer checked the time and wondered where it had all gone. She tidied up the clothes in the bedroom and then went off to the kitchen.

‘Bring me!’ said the teddy. She picked him up and put him on the kitchen table. He was at least a memory of who she really was, or at least used to be.

She put on a pinafore, got on with peeling the potatoes, putting

them on for mash, preparing carrots and broccoli and cutting up onions and putting together the shepherd's pie. It was a meal she made frequently. One of the very few she could make that Joe seemed to like. Or at least, didn't complain about. Concentrating on her work seemed to help her focus and get all those voices out of her head.

'All except me,' said the teddy.

In due course she had the meal under control and had regained some of her composure. She hung up her pinafore and made another mug of tea but decided to drink it at the kitchen table to avoid the clairvoyant television. She was just draining her mug at six o'clock by the kitchen clock when Joe turned up, home from work.

'Hello darling,' said Jennifer. 'Have you had a good day? It's been very quiet here since you left this morning.'

Keys

Death of a Piano, by Brynneth Nimue Brown. Memory, melancholy and loss.

(No) Lingua Franca, by Irena Peterson Pavliuk. ???

Piper Finchling, by Steven C. Davis. Exploration, wonder and curiosity.

Pipe, glass, bottle, by Sadie Kaye. Abstract vs. concrete, Material vs. virtual; transformed, repurposed, appropriated.

The Border, by Richard Bruce Clay. ???

A Last Horizon, by Brendan Hawthorne. B minor. One of Brendan's favourite chords!

The Room, by Irena Peterson Pavliuk. Confinement, restlessness, absorption, irreconcilability, legacy, metamorphosis.

Being someone, by Sadie Kaye Mock heroic, in E $\flat$ major.

Otherworld, by Viktor A. T. Rowlands. Melancholy, indigo, dusky, cprepuscular, fading (as of twilight), courageous.

The darker sides of AI, by Emily Perry. No key???

Unrequited, by Sam Sutton. Key of C $\sharp$ minor – poignant, brooding, fragile.

Despite the distance, I stand next to you, by Lucia Sellars. No key???

The Border Gap, by Irena Peterson Pavliuk. In D minor ?

A Vision of Emancipation, by Grace Reynolds. inspired, prophetic, spirited

The House of Gods, by Ben Morgan. cyclical, grand, mischievous, otherworldly, climactic

Contemplation of the body in the body, by Lucia Sellars. No key???

A Warmer Kind of Grief, by Andrew Cheffings. In a key which expresses grief, is heavy, wet, and warm. A $\flat$ minor.

Jennifer, by Sadie Kaye. Timid, insecure, can't make up her mind, can't express herself, C $\sharp$ major.

The 24 musical keys

I list here all the 24 classical *keys*. Each key has a *tonic note* (there are 12 of these) and is either *major* or *minor*. Each key has an associated number of *sharps* or *flats* which indicates how it is written. Some keys can be written ‘equivalently’ in either sharps or flats, but note that the equivalence of keys written differently, for example F $\sharp$ major and G $\flat$ major, only means these would in principle sound exactly the same if played on a piano keyboard or computer. Most musicians, however, respond differently to these keys when playing – especially if the performance is on a different instrument where other nuances of intonation are possible – and so in practice the keys could sound different and convey a different ‘mood’.

In general, the more sharps or flats a key has the more unusual and esoteric it sounds. Keys with few sharps or flats sound more ‘normal.’

I also include a few words about each key that I have seen written on the internet. (I don’t agree with them all.)

SPK

C major. No sharps or flats. Pure, innocence, simplicity, naïvety, children's talk. Often the first (easiest) key we learn to play in.

A minor. No sharps or flats. Pious, feminine, tender.

G major. One sharp. Rustic, idyllic, lyrical, calm, gentle, peaceful.

E minor. One sharp. Naïve, innocent, lament.

D major. Two sharps. Triumphant. Confident, victorious, rejoicing, bright.

B minor. Two sharps. Quiet acceptance of fate. Submission.

A major. Three sharps. Innocent love, satisfaction, cheerfulness and trust.

F♯ minor. Three sharps. Gloomy. Resentment and discontent.

E major. Four sharps. Fresh, brash, new, happy, joy, laughing, pleasure.

C♯ minor. Four sharps. Penitential, lamentation, intimate, sighing.

B major. Five sharps. Colourful, passionate. Can incorporate anger, rage, jealousy, fury, despair.

G♯ minor aka A♭ minor. Five sharps or seven flats. Grumbling, suffocating, wailing, struggle, difficulty.

F♯ major aka G♭ major. Six sharps or six flats. Triumph over difficulty.

D♯ minor aka E♭ minor. Six sharps or six flats. Anxiety, distress, despair, depression, gloom.

D♭ major aka C♯ major. Five flats or seven sharps. Majestic.

B♭ minor aka A♯ minor. Five flats or seven sharps. Quaint, dressed in a garment of night. Surly and mocking.

A♭ major. Four flats. Pomp. Grand. Possibly: death, grave, judgement, eternity.

F minor. Four flats. Melancholy. Sombre, emotional.

E $\flat$ major. Three flats. Considered by many composers as 'heroic.' Also devotion.

C minor. Three flats. Tragic, fate, enigmatic, brooding, emotionally charged, melancholy, solemnity.

B $\flat$ major. Two flats. Noble. Cheerful, clear conscience and hope.

G minor. Two flats. Sweetness, tenderness, serious, magnificent, discontent, unease, intensity.

F major. One flat. Pastoral. Countryside. Calm.

D minor. One flat. Melancholy, feminine, brooding humours.